

Hardware Requirements

Creating a multimedia package involves working with an assortment of heavy media files. Hence, you need a high-end machine to work efficiently. You need at least a Pentium MMX and above with at least 128 MB RAM. You would also need a soundcard, a graphics accelerator card, a video card and a good set of speakers. If you dabble in Digital Imaging, like a lot of multimedia authors do, there's nothing to beat a digital tablet.

You also need plenty of hard disk space to work with all those raw, unedited media files that will ultimately get optimised for the final package. A minute of good quality sound (22 KHz, 16 bit,

stereo) takes up around 3 MB of space; a minute of uncompressed video can take a little more than 100 MB of space. Graphics and animation too are heavy on memory. Besides, to try out the optimum playback and to play around you need a lot of space. And don't forget the backups—each backup can be a space-hogging affair.

Since multimedia authoring requires work on many windows, you could connect up two monitors to speed up your work—one monitor to view your working/coding/scoring window, and the other where you can check out the final presentation simultaneously.

on the remote computer. With the rest, you didn't have any such problems.

Miscellaneous features: Adobe LiveMotion was the only software that possessed a good set of useable filters, which have been



Authorware has good scripting capabilities

borrowed from Adobe Photoshop's vast repository. Director's latest release lets you do 3D animation. Illuminatus Opus has a feature called Hotspot with which you can easily draw an object with a fill. However, in the editor window it will always be semi-transparent so that you can see what's underneath; in the final presentation you will be able to see the actual effects of the hotspot. The newer version of Flash extends its functionality by providing support for XML as well.

Ease of Use

Multimedia authoring packages can be complicated to work with. Hence, the interface and ease of use are important aspects—you want to be able to operate and access advanced features without juggling through many options.

Formula Graphic 97 sported a very dull interface. In order to add any sort of

element to the screen, say a picture or text, you first have to select a specific area and only then can you get the picture on the screen. Even Illuminatus Opus had an absolutely cramped and intrusive default interface, though you could customise and remove those extra windows that occupied the screen at startup.

Adobe LiveMotion's interface is reminiscent of that of Adobe Photoshop. With the exception of specific toolbars that allow access to the multimedia authoring effects and features, there are the familiar toolbars and buttons to allow access to photo and image editing tools.

Macromedia's Flash 5 has an interface similar to its earlier version. However, it will definitely be difficult for a novice to operate this software. Even those who have

used the previous version may find it difficult as certain common features such as Motion Tweening and Shape Tweening suddenly seem to be missing from their familiar locations. However, this version of Flash incorporates a lot of new features and many features have been revamped and grouped according to function. And to make things easier, the software does offer an option to revert to the older Flash 4 type display.

Macromedia's Authorware is quite simple to use as there are Knowledge Objects (wizards and templates to create forms) that guide you so you do not find it that difficult to work in this software even if you are using it for the first time. Macromedia Director 8.5's interface does not seem any different from its previous versions and hence, if you are used to the previous versions you would find it very familiar to work with this one too.

Help at hand

Since multimedia authoring packages tend to have a steep learning curve, the help file is indispensable for most users. The Macromedia products, Director, Authorware and Flash, really score in this respect. Flash has an excellent set of help files that take you right from how to animate, mask, draw objects, and even how to apply actions to buttons, to the basics of scripting. Most of the advanced features of Director are normally worked out using the Lingo scripting language. But to make this task easier, Director has a library of predefined scripts and all you have to do is drag and drop them on the objects you want.

More than just the Tool

Since multimedia authoring involves working with a lot of media, if you have your hands on other media manipulation tools you certainly have an advantage over someone who just knows coding. Some of the tools that multimedia authors normally use are:

Photoshop: so that you don't have to depend on the graphic artist for that little crop or those minor tweaks. But take care that your digital artist has the final say.

Adobe Premiere: You can compress the videos here according to your authoring tool's playback support.

Sound Forge or some other audio editor: Cut a plop here or mute a slip there—

these things are easily done with a WYSIWYG audio editor. There are many in the market, both free and paid. Just get the one that has the right features for you.

Flash: Many multimedia applications nowadays readily integrate Flash files. Being familiar with Flash's capabilities will certainly make things easier and faster for you.

Image optimisers: With the Web being used as a delivery medium for multimedia content, knowing those little utilities that can save space and make playback easier will give you a definite advantage. Many image editors now come with an optimiser built in.